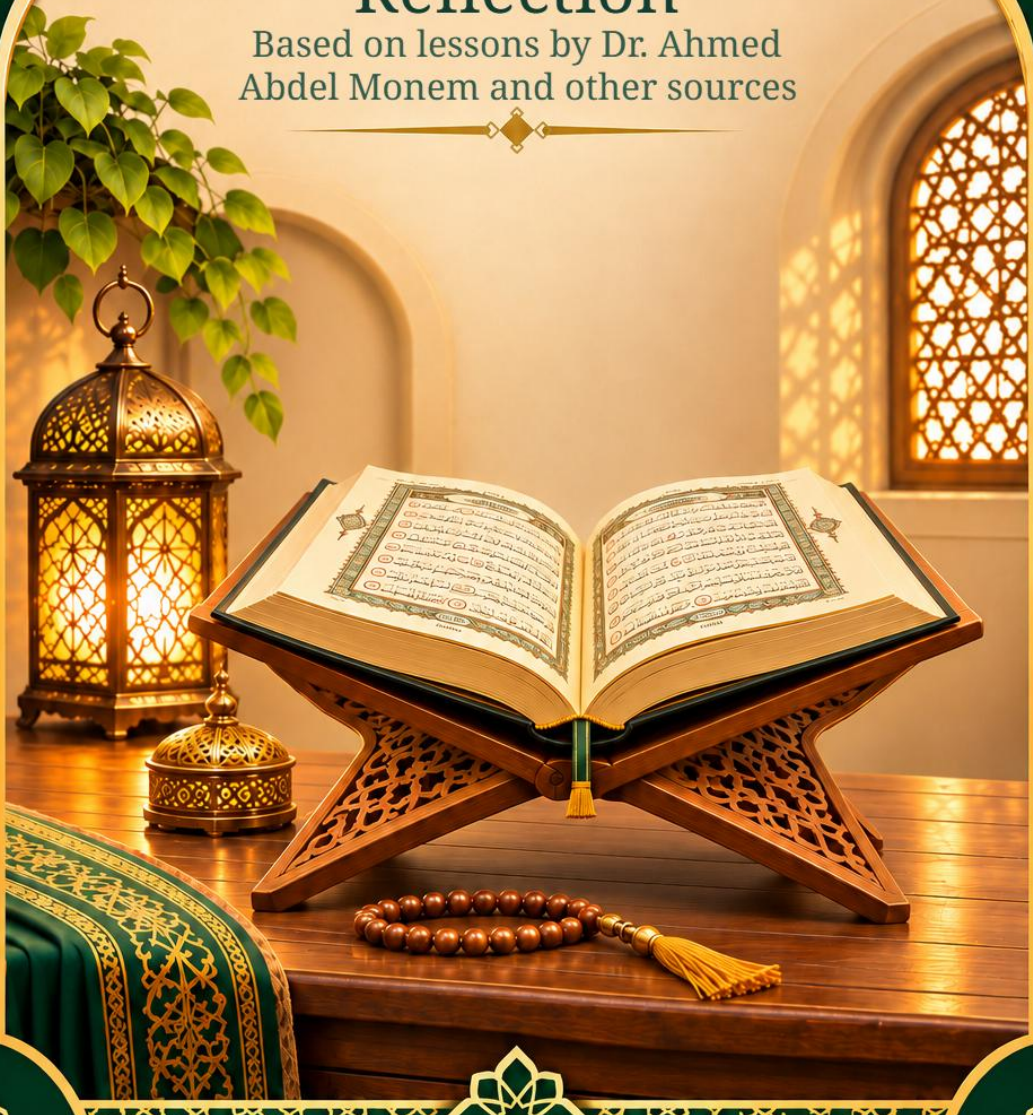
Iman Companion

Quran Reflection

Based on lessons by Dr. Ahmed Abdel Monem and other sources



Quran Reflection

Surah Al-Ikhlas — Reflections

Iman Companion

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Verse 1

قُلْ هُوَ ٱللَّهُ أَحَدٌ ١ (Surah Al-Ikhlas, 112:1)

Say: “He is Allah, the One[1];[1]

Allah introduces Himself to us in a few words that convey a truth the heart cannot do without: Say: “He is Allah, the One[1]; (Surah Al-Ikhlas, 112:1) In His mercy, He did not provide food for people’s bodies and leave their souls without guidance. He sent messengers, revealed scriptures, and made His revelation a source of life and light, as He says: Likewise, We have revealed to you a revelation by Our command. (Surah Ash-Shuraa, 42:52) One of the greatest ways this revelation brings the heart to life is by acquainting it with its Lord. So we should not read Surah Al-Ikhlas as words a Muslim has known since childhood and therefore need not pause over. Its words may remain in our memory while their influence fades from our fears, hopes, and choices.

The opening Say: (Surah Al-Ikhlas, 112:1) is a command. The Prophet, peace and blessings be upon him, conveyed the surah just as it was revealed to him, including the word of command itself. He neither composed his own description of Allah nor left out any of the revelation he received. The inclusion of this command reminds us that the oneness of Allah is to be learned and taught, rather than kept as private knowledge. A Muslim

[1] [1] He is Alone, without a partner, indivisible and distinct from all else. The only true deity, unique in His essence, attributes, and actions.

receives what Allah has made known about Himself, then teaches it to others with the clarity of the Quran, without letting complicated expressions and arguments become a barrier between people and this truth. The word rendered He (Surah Al-Ikhlas, 112:1) has been understood as a pronoun that introduces a matter of great importance: it prepares the listener for something momentous that deserves close attention—Allah's unique oneness.

"Allah" is the proper name of our Lord, glorified is He. The word Ahad then affirms His uniqueness: He is One in His essence, attributes, and actions, with no partner in any of them. One proposed distinction between al-Wahid and al-Ahad is that the oneness meant here is more than counting one as opposed to two: it is uniqueness without equal in the perfection of His essence, attributes, and actions. To keep this from remaining an abstract idea, reflect on what you have read in the Quran about Allah's actions. You see who saves from destruction, supports the oppressed, destroys the oppressor, heals the sick, and guides those who have gone astray: every day He is engaged in some matters[1] (Surah Ar-Rahman, 55:29)[2]. When you reach this surah near the end of the Quran, it is as though it answers a question stirring in your heart: Who has done all of this? It is Allah, the One.

It was Allah who saved Abraham from the fire. When Abraham was thrown into it, he said: Allah is Sufficient for us, and He is the best Protector[3].[3][4] The divine command came: O fire, be cool and

[2] [1] Such as giving life and causing death, enriching some and impoverishing others, elevating some and debasing others, etc.

[3] Sahih al-Bukhari (4563)

safe for Abraham. (Surah Al-Anbiya, 21:69)[5] It was Allah who protected Joseph from the women's schemes. Joseph said, Unless you protect me from their guile, I may succumb to them (Surah Yusuf, 12:33), and his Lord answered his prayer and protected him from their schemes. It was Allah who heard Jonah in the darkness of the whale's belly and saved him. Jonah called out, None has the right to be worshiped except You. Glory be to You! I have certainly done wrong (Surah Al-Anbiya, 21:87)[6], and the answer came: So We answered his prayer and rescued him from distress. (Surah Al-Anbiya, 21:88) The ordeals differ—a fire, a temptation, distress in the depths of darkness—but the One who has the power to deliver from them is the same.

You encounter this knowledge again when you read of Pharaoh's drowning, Allah's kindness to Joseph in prison, or His help for the believers at Badr despite their weakness: Allah had helped you at Badr when you were weak (Surah Aal-E-Imran, 3:123). The actions of the one Lord are varied; His servant comes to know Him through these accounts as well as through verses describing His names and attributes. When your heart longs for His kindness and mercy, you know where to turn. Then come His words: Allah, the Eternal

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[4] [3] This is one of the greatest Dhikr (remembrance) during times of hardship. Ibn 'Abbās (رضي الله عنهما) reported: "Hasbunā Allāh wa ni'ma al-Wakīl (Allah suffices us, He is the best of Protectors), was said by Abraham (عليه السلام) when he was thrown in the fire and was said by Muhammad (ﷺ) when it was said: "People have regrouped for you, so fear them", their belief grew firmer and they said: "Allah suffices us, He is the best of Protectors"." [Al-Bukhārī: 4563]

[5] [1] It is reported in an authentic Hadīth that Abraham said, while being thrown into the fire, "Allah is sufficient for us and He is the best Protector."

[6] [2] The darkness of the night, the sea, and the whale's belly.

Refuge[1]. (Surah Al-Ikhlas, 112:2)[7] This helps us understand the greatness of the surah despite its brevity. The Prophet, peace and blessings be upon him, said that Surah Al-Ikhlas is equivalent to a third of the Qur'an.[8] A listener might expect a surah of such standing to be long, yet it has only four verses. This draws attention to the weight of the meaning they bring together, rather than merely the number of their words.

The same lesson is reinforced by what happened when the Prophet, peace and blessings be upon him, asked Ubayy ibn Ka'b about the greatest verse in Allah's Book. Ubayy named Ayat al-Kursi; the Prophet affirmed his answer and congratulated him on his knowledge. It is a verse that makes Allah known through His knowledge, His sustaining of all things, and His dominion. Likewise, Al-Fatihah, which the Prophet described as the greatest surah in the Quran, brings together praise of Allah and the plea for His guidance. In seeking the Quran's guidance, we should not pass over these clear meanings to pursue subtle insights alone. Reflection also means allowing a familiar truth to return to the heart, alive and influential, after we have grown used to repeating it.

The verses heard by a group of jinn moved them to declare their faith and renounce worshiping partners with Allah: that guides to the right way, so we have believed in it, and we will never associate anyone with our Lord. (Surah Al-Jinn, 72:2) The fruit of listening is more than admiration for the words: it is knowing the

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[7] [1] He is absolute, perfect, complete, self-sufficient; the one eternally and constantly required and sought; all existence depend upon Him; all matters ultimately return to Him.

[8] Sahih Muslim (811)

One to be worshiped and devoting worship to Him alone. This worship is Allah's right over His creation. It is not a marginal concern to be crowded out by everything else until it is forgotten. The Prophet, peace and blessings be upon him, explained to Mu'adh that Allah's right over His servants is that they should worship Him (Alone) and should not worship any besides Him.[9] People may spend a long time considering their rights over one another, then overlook the right of the One who created them all. The verse brings them back to this foundation.

Acknowledging it is not an empty phrase with no consequences. While Bilal, may Allah be pleased with him, was being tortured, he would say, Ahad, Ahad (One, One)[10]. His tormentors could hurt his body, but he did not grant them the power to change whom he worshiped. These words declared to whom his servitude belonged, which is why they weighed so heavily on those who wanted to turn him away from his faith. The biography of the Prophet also records that One, One! was the Muslims' rallying cry at Badr. The truth that steadied a believer under oppression is the same truth he carries in strength. It is not a belief to abandon when suffering becomes severe or some worldly possession makes him feel self-sufficient.

Every day the heart deals with people and practical means, pulled in different directions by fear, hope, and eager desire. It needs this knowledge renewed, rather than heard once and then left behind. This is why it is prescribed to repeat the declaration None has the right to be worshipped but Allah, the Alone Who has no partners, to Him belongs Dominion and to Him belong all the Praises, and He

[9] Sahih al-Bukhari (2856)

[10] Sunan Ibn Majah (150)

has power over all things[11] one hundred times in a day. The words are familiar, but repeating them brings the heart back to the One who governs all things when its surroundings almost distract it from Him. The merit of Al-Ikhlas encourages frequent recitation. In view of its equivalence to a third of the Quran, it is hoped that someone who recites it three times will receive the reward of reciting the Quran.[12]

Its meanings are renewed in prayer as well: in Witr, the Prophet, peace and blessings be upon him, would recite Al-A'la, then Al-Kafirun, then Al-Ikhlas; in the two voluntary units before the obligatory dawn prayer, he would recite Al-Kafirun and Al-Ikhlas. Al-Kafirun renounces the worship of anything besides Allah, while Al-Ikhlas affirms His oneness. This is why Al-Kafirun has also been called a surah of sincere devotion. In the quiet of the night, the believer reviews his day in light of this truth, drawing on the way night prayer helps bring the tongue and heart into harmony: Indeed, worship at night is more effective[1] and more conducive to proper recitation[2]. (Surah Al-Muzzammil, 73:6)[13][14] Then, before going out among people, he begins his day by renewing it.

One lesson to reflect on in this repetition between the darkness of night and the light of dawn is that Allah's oneness does not change as circumstances change. Conditions may grow harsh or ease, and believers may be weak or strong, but their Lord remains One

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[11] Sahih al-Bukhari (3293)

[12] This is an inference about hoped-for reward, not a substitute for reading the Quran.

[13] [1] Or "getting up at night is more difficult…," meaning that it can only be done by sincere believers.

[14] [2] i.e., for reciting, hearing, and understanding of the Qur'an.

and their worship belongs to Him alone. This truth is not altered for a passing advantage; instead, actions and choices are reconsidered in its light.

Verse 2

(Surah Al-Ikhlas, 112:2) ٢ ٱللَّهُ ٱلصَّمَدُ

Allah, the Eternal Refuge[1].

Once you know that Allah is One, to whom do you bring your needs? The answer follows: Allah, the Eternal Refuge[1]. (Surah Al-Ikhlas, 112:2) He is the One to whom people turn for refuge and bring their needs. The name Allah is stated again, rather than replaced with the pronoun “He.” His name is thus repeated on the tongue, the heart recalls Him, and the worshiper seeks blessing by remembering Him. The Samad to whom you turn is Allah, whose unique oneness you have come to know. Several explanations have been given for al-Samad, and the name should not be reduced to just one of them. One is that He has no interior cavity and neither eats nor drinks. This expresses His freedom from the needs of created beings, as He says: Who feeds but is not fed (Surah Al-Anam, 6:14).

A human being needs food and drink, with one need following another: scarcely is one met before another arises. Allah, however, needs no one. Another explanation is that He is perfect in His attributes. Ibn ‘Abbas is reported to have explained it as the Master whose mastery is perfect, the Forbearing whose forbearance is perfect, the Self-Sufficient whose self-sufficiency is perfect, the All-Knowing whose knowledge is perfect, and the Wise whose wisdom is perfect. It has also been explained as the Master to whom creation turns with its needs. The connection between

these meanings becomes clear: they turn to Him because He is self-sufficient and they are in need, and because His knowledge, power, and mercy are perfect—not because He needs someone to help Him meet their needs.

He is not one of several counterparts with differing abilities. He is the One without equal, the Samad to whom perfection belongs. When people cannot solve a problem, they ordinarily look for someone who can, seeking out the most capable person within reach. How, then, can someone know his Lord's perfection yet attach his heart to someone who cannot himself do without Him? Al-Samad is the One before whom you lay your needs, turning to Him with all the neediness and hope in your heart, whether you possess some means of meeting those needs or can find none. This is not asking with the tongue while the heart remains turned elsewhere. It is a real attachment to the One you ask. To illustrate the longing and need in this attachment, some linguistic discussions cite an expression meaning the weaned camel calf yearned for its mother. The calf in this illustration has been weaned; when separated from its mother, it longs intensely for her, crying out as if to complain that it cannot bear being away from her.

It has been suggested that this meaning is connected to the derivation of the name Allah. This is a reported view, not an etymology asserted with certainty. The image is intended to help us understand the yearning heart, without likening Allah to His creation. Just as love for a mother differs from love for a friend or a child, the heart has a devotion, love, and need that can rightly be directed only to Allah. Sincere devotion includes recognizing these feelings within yourself, nourishing them by remembering your Lord, and directing them to Him, rather than allowing created

beings and practical means to take them over. You see this reliance in the story of Moses' mother, when she was commanded: when you fear for him, cast him into the river (Surah Al-Qasas, 28:7).

She feared for her son, yet his safety lay in obeying Allah's command, even though the water appeared to be a place of danger. What mattered here was her trust in the One who commanded her and gave her His promise, rather than the outward appearance of the path alone. You see a similar certainty in Hud's stand before his people. He said: So plot against me all together, then give me no respite. (Surah Hud, 11:55) He then explained what he relied on: I put my trust in Allah, my Lord and your Lord. (Surah Hud, 11:56)[15] He concluded with My Lord is on a straight path[2]. (Surah Hud, 11:56) He knew his Lord's power and trusted His justice and governance. One of His names is al-Mu'min, and His servant is secure in knowing that his Lord will neither wrong him nor break His promise.

He therefore did not weigh his own strength against his people's while forgetting the One who held everyone's affairs in His hands. This is why knowing Allah's oneness is connected with security, as in His words: Those who believe and do not mix their faith with falsehood[1] are the ones who will be secure, and it is they who are rightly guided. (Surah Al-Anam, 6:82)[16] Just as you turn to Allah with your needs, you turn to His revelation to learn what pleases Him and what He commands. Turning to Him does not mean asking for His gifts and then living as though you could do without His guidance. None of this conflicts with using practical means;

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[15] [2] The path of Truth and Justice, as He Almighty does not deal anyone wrongfully.

[16] [1] i.e., they do not worship others besides Allah.

Allah Himself has made them part of how life works. Someone who wants a harvest tills the soil, plants the seed, and waters and tends it. Leaving the field unplanted and asking for a harvest to fall from the sky is not the ordinary path Allah has established.

Someone who is ill looks for medicine and seeks treatment. The Prophet, peace and blessings be upon him, said, There is no disease that Allah has created, except that He also has created its treatment.[17] Yet even while seeking treatment, the sick person remembers that healing comes from Allah, joining effort with the prayer heal the patient, for You are the Healer. No healing is of any avail but Yours[18]. Likewise, a person works for a living without treating work as an independent provider, and takes the means to victory while remaining certain that victory only comes from Allah (Surah Al-Anfal, 8:10). The problem lies not in using a means, but in forgetting its Lord until fear and hope become attached to the instrument alone.

Means may produce results, fail to do so, or lead to something quite different from what was expected. If someone's heart was attached to Allah from the outset, his connection with Him will not be severed when one of his means fails. Beyond the adornments of the earth that absorb our attention, the truth remains that Allah governs all affairs. He is the First[1] and the Last[2] (Surah Al-Hadid, 57:3)[19][20]: no means begins independently of Him, and no outcome passes into a dominion beyond His. Careful preparation and complete reliance came together in the migration to Madinah.

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[17] Sahih al-Bukhari (5678)

[18] Sahih al-Bukhari (5743)

[19] [1] Before Whom nothing existed; the foremost; the uppermost.

[20] [2] Eternal after Whom nothing remains.

The Prophet, peace and blessings be upon him, arranged the route, guidance, and provisions. Yet the pursuers came so close to the cave that Abu Bakr, may Allah be pleased with him, said that if one of them looked beneath his feet, he would see them.

The Prophet's reply was not a list of the precautions they had taken. He said, O Abu Bakr! What do you think of two (persons) the third of whom is Allah?[21] The Quran also records what he told his companion: Do not grieve; Allah is with us. (Surah At-Tawbah, 9:40) Trust in Allah had not begun only once their resources were exhausted. It was with him before he took action, as he acted, and when danger intensified. Miracles, too, show that familiar means do not constrain Allah's power: a staff becomes a snake, the sea parts, and Jesus brings the dead to life by Allah's permission. These signs free people from the illusion that what they are used to is all that is possible. A believer does not make faith conditional on witnessing something extraordinary in every ordeal. The Quran has come to him as revelation to guide him and as a sign of the truth of the message. From it he learns belief in the unseen, a quality of those who are guided described at the beginning of Al-Baqarah: those who believe in the unseen (Surah Al-Baqarah, 2:3).

His heart should not lose its way among the branching paths of practical means and forget the One to whom all affairs return. Changing worldly circumstances reveal the difference between attachment to Allah and attachment to His gifts. Allah says of some people: There are some people who worship Allah on the edge [of faith][1]: if something good comes to them, they are content

[21] Sahih al-Bukhari (3653)

(Surah Al-Hajj, 22:11)[22][23]. Such a person is reassured by the worldly good he receives, and when it disappears his stance becomes unsettled. The world never stays the same: We alternate among people these days (Surah Aal-E-Imran, 3:140). Someone who turns to Allah, however, finds the foundation of reassurance in the One who does not die, obeying His words: Put your trust in the Ever-Living Who never dies (Surah Al-Furqan, 25:58).

The Prophet's bedtime supplication expresses this reliance in the words I have sought shelter for my back with You[24]. Reliance is not simply a subject to discuss while leaving our fears and hopes untouched; it means bringing our worries to our Lord while trusting Him. In saying O Allah! Thou art Peace, and peace comes from Thee[25], a person remembers that the reassurance he seeks is not limited to an improvement in some passing circumstance: he asks his Lord for it. Knowing Allah's beautiful names therefore requires living with their meanings, rather than simply memorizing definitions. Someone reading Joseph's story sees Allah's gentle care for him throughout its events. The name al-Latif then touches him in a way that a lifeless expression detached from life does not.

He may hear of Allah's self-sufficiency and generosity, then experience a need that turns him to Him, discovering the effect of that name on his heart in a way he did not when he merely heard it. Frequent exposure to great truths, however, can become a habit that weakens our response. Someone visiting a sick person may feel his heart soften and remember the blessing of health, while

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[22] [1] i.e., with uncertainty, hypocrisy, or heedlessness.

[23] [2] lit., they tumble on their faces, i.e., turn back to disbelief.

[24] Sahih al-Bukhari (247)

[25] Sahih Muslim (591)

some hospital workers grow familiar with repeated scenes of illness and death and need to renew the lessons they draw from them. Someone arriving at the Sacred Sanctuary may long for it and weep on reaching it, while some who work there regularly need to struggle against familiarity so that it does not veil the greatness of the place.

The point concerns the effect of familiarity; it is not a judgment on a profession or on the hearts of those who work in it. Likewise, someone who spends a long time discussing Allah in the abstract, yet experiences little humility or sense of need before Him, needs to return to the Quran and receive what it says about his Lord, rather than be content with analyzing words. His Creator knows best what will speak to his heart: Does He not know His Own creation[1], when He is the Most Subtle, the All-Aware? (Surah Al-Mulk, 67:14)[26] One supplication that brings together calling on Allah by His names and benefiting from His words asks Him to make the Quran the springtime of my heart, the light of my chest, the clearing of my sorrow, and the removal of my worry[27].

This orientation does not become firmly established through listening to an admonition alone. Action plants in the heart a regard for what a person works for. People do not need a lesson every morning to remind them of the value of their worldly affairs. Their daily involvement, the effort they spend acquiring what they want, and the time they devote to it all strengthen their attachment. Likewise, someone who makes an effort to maintain prayer, sets aside time for remembrance and supplication, and labors to learn and teach others will grow in reverence for what he devotes

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[26] [1] Or does He not know those whom He created?

[27] Musnad Ahmad (3712)

himself to. Hearing about sincere devotion or sharing words about it, while changing nothing in one's actions, cannot take the place of striving to reform the heart. Praise and reward are connected to action: How excellent is the reward of those who do [righteous] deeds! (Surah Aal-E-Imran, 3:136)

Moving from scattered desires to reassurance in Allah is therefore a repeated effort: knowledge followed by worship, and worship through which that knowledge takes effect afresh. This keeps the words from remaining merely a definition explained by the tongue: Allah, the Eternal Refuge[1]. (Surah Al-Ikhlas, 112:2) They become a truth to which the heart returns in its needs, fears, efforts, and choices.

Verse 3

(Surah Al-Ikhlas, 112:3) لَمْ يَلِدْ وَلَمْ يُولَدْ ٣

He neither begets nor is He begotten,

Allah declares Himself free of having offspring or being born. He has no child and was not born of a parent, as He says: He neither begets nor is He begotten, (Surah Al-Ikhlas, 112:3) This truth prevents us from imagining the Lord in the way we imagine created beings with family lineages. It is reported that the idolaters said to the Prophet, peace and blessings be upon him, Name the lineage of your Lord for us.[28] Surah Al-Ikhlas was then revealed. Some scholars graded the core of this report hasan, or acceptable. The reports differ over who asked: some identify idolaters and others People of the Book. The point here is to understand the

[28] Jami al-Tirmidhi (3364)

error revealed by the form of the question. It is as though they wanted to place the Creator within the genealogies of created beings. The revelation introducing Him rejects that comparison, rather than supplying the kind of lineage they requested.

This differs from the question that arises in the heart of someone seeking guidance: Who is my Lord, and how can I know and worship Him? People ask about their own origins and may be deeply concerned to know their father, mother, and ancestry. Indeed, it is reported that ‘Abdullah ibn Hudhafah asked the Prophet, peace and blessings be upon him, who his father was. If this concerns a person, he has even more reason not to overlook knowing his Creator. But seeking to know Him is one thing; assuming that Allah has a lineage like a human being is another. Allah says: When My slaves ask you concerning Me, I am indeed near[1]. (Surah Al-Baqarah, 2:186)[29] His servant seeks to know his Lord and draw near to Him, and revelation answers with guidance, rather than encouraging him to measure Allah against himself.

Surah Al-Ikhlas is a preserved answer for the person who asks, and awakens the question in someone whom worldly concerns have distracted from it. Attributing offspring to Allah is not a trivial claim to repeat without understanding its implications. In a hadith qudsi—divine speech reported by the Prophet—Allah explains that the son of Adam denies Him by saying He will not bring him back as He created him, then says: As for his abusing Me, it is his saying that Allah has begotten children, while I am the One, the Self-Sufficient Master Whom all creatures need, I beget not, nor

[29] [1] Allah’s nearness means that one does not need to raise his voice or to ask for intercession in order that his prayers be answered.

was I begotten, and there is none like unto Me.[30] Just as denying the resurrection is a denial of His truth, claiming that He has offspring disparages Him and contradicts what He has made known about Himself.

The Quran depicts the enormity of this claim in these words: at which the heavens are about to be torn apart, the earth split asunder, and the mountains tumble down. (Surah Maryam, 19:90) Then the next verse states the reason: because they have ascribed to the Most Compassionate a son. (Surah Maryam, 19:91) If this is how its effect on the heavens, earth, and mountains is portrayed, how can a believer pass over it heedless of his Lord's right? Reverence for Allah requires declaring Him free of this claim and recognizing its falsehood, rather than becoming so accustomed to it that its gravity fades from the heart. Denying that Allah has a lineage also corrects the way we turn to Him. Someone might try to gain access to a person in authority through his father or son, or think a relative could compel him to respond. Allah's pleasure, however, is not sought on this human model.

He has no father or son through whom pressure could be brought upon Him or something He disapproves of obtained. His servant calls on Him and repents to Him directly. This brings relief and mercy to the sinner: he does not need to expose what has been concealed about him to another human being who would grant him forgiveness, nor take his confession to an idol or to someone he imagines has authority over Allah. Moses said, My Lord, I have wronged myself, so forgive me, (Surah Al-Qasas, 28:16) and Allah tells us: Then He forgave him (Surah Al-Qasas, 28:16). He recognized his wrong and brought his need to his Lord. The door

[30] Sahih al-Bukhari (4974)

of repentance is not in the keeping of an imagined relative of Allah; it is with Allah Himself.

Verse 4

وَلَمْ يَكُن لَّهُۥ كُفُوًا أَحَدٌۢ ٤ (Surah Al-Ikhlas, 112:4)

and there is none comparable to Him."[1][31]

The surah closes by denying that anyone is comparable to Allah: and there is none comparable to Him."[1] (Surah Al-Ikhlas, 112:4) He has no counterpart or equal in His essence, attributes, or actions. His words Do you know anyone equal to Him? (Surah Maryam, 19:65) have been explained as asking whether anyone knows a rival or a likeness to Him. The answer that settles in the heart of someone who worships Allah alone is that he knows no counterpart to his Lord to whom he could turn instead. Revelation has taught him this foundation: There is nothing like unto Him[1] (Surah Ash-Shuraa, 42:11)[32]. So it is wrong to approach Allah's names and attributes by measuring them against human circumstances, then reject whatever one cannot imagine a created being possessing. One form of this error is to imagine that what is hidden from people is hidden from Allah, as in the answer to those who spoke privately about concealing what they knew: Do they not know that Allah knows what they conceal and what they reveal? (Surah Al-Baqarah, 2:77)

Another is to make belief in the Creator depend on seeing and touching, as people do with idols. The Children of Israel said, we

[31] [1] The Prophet (ﷺ) says that reading this surah (surat al-Ikhlās) equals reading one third of the Qur'an. [Al-Bukhāri and Muslim]

[32] [1] In His essence, His attributes, or His deeds.

will never believe you until we see Allah openly (Surah Al-Baqarah, 2:55), and, on another occasion, make for us a god just as they have gods. (Surah Al-Araf, 7:138) The forms of the error change, but its root remains the same: subjecting knowledge of Allah to what people are accustomed to in created beings. Sincere devotion, by contrast, receives what Allah has told us about Himself while affirming that He has no likeness. It neither invents attributes for Him nor denies Him a perfection because human beings cannot attain it. Knowing that He has no equal is not remote from the heart's needs. It ends the search for another god to provide what one seeks from Allah, or for a power that could force Allah to do its bidding.

The meanings of the surah therefore unfold in one direction: you know that He is One, so you turn to Him with your needs; then you learn that He has no child, parent, or counterpart, so your worship is not divided among different beings, each imagined to control a share of your affairs. The Quran illustrates the effect of this oneness through its comparison of a slave owned by several quarrelsome masters, and a slave owned by only one master (Surah Az-Zumar, 39:29). The first is pulled by conflicting demands: scarcely has he satisfied one before another presses him. The second knows whom he serves. Likewise, a heart that attaches its fears and hopes to everyone and every means becomes scattered and exhausted. In His mercy, Allah commanded it to worship Him alone, rather than carry the burden of pleasing many gods.

Gathering one's concerns around Allah becomes a way out of this fragmentation. Knowing His oneness becomes a foundation for obedience, reassurance, and referring to His Book for judgment, rather than a statement detached from life. One subtle point in the order of the Quran's closing surahs is that this knowledge is

followed by seeking refuge. Al-Falaq opens with Say, "I seek refuge with the Lord of the daybreak, (Surah Al-Falaq, 113:1) Then An-Nas opens with Say, "I seek refuge with the Lord of mankind, (Surah An-Nas, 114:1) The reader has passed through accounts of created beings and seen their weakness, and accounts of deliverance, victory, and mercy, learning who holds all of this in His hands. Once certain of the One, the Eternal Refuge, he brings his fear of evil to Him.

In Al-Falaq he seeks refuge from the evil of what Allah has created, from the evil of night as it falls, from those who blow on knots, and from the envier; in An-Nas he seeks refuge from the retreating whisperer who corrupts the heart from within. These two surahs do not turn to a subject separate from Allah's oneness. They show the fruit of knowing the One who has no equal. The Prophet, peace and blessings be upon him, told 'Uqbah ibn 'Amir about these two surahs: use them when seeking refuge in Allah, for no one can use anything to compare with them for the purpose.[33] The believer thus turns to his Lord with the words He taught him, attentive to their meaning. Holding fast to the Quran does not mean a person will never be harmed. The Prophet, peace and blessings be upon him, faced plots and envy, and the harm he suffered from magic is established. Of those filled with rage on hearing the Reminder, the Quran says: The disbelievers would almost strike you down with their malicious gazes when they hear the Reminder (Surah Al-Qalam, 68:51).

The believer needs to know to whom to turn when harm confronts him, rather than assume that merely following the path of truth will prevent harm from occurring. This is why an attentive heart and

[33] Sunan Abi Dawud (1463)

certainty matter when seeking refuge. A person should not recite his Lord's names while heedless of the One he is calling on, then treat the recitation as words that work by themselves. An unattributed saying illustrates the point: The staff depends on its wielder, and Al-Fatihah on its reciter. Just as an instrument's effectiveness cannot be separated from the state of the person using it, seeking refuge cannot be separated from the sincerity of the person seeking it and his attachment to Allah. Allah is the One who determines relief and its timing. A servant does not set the moment of the answer, even when sincere in his supplication.

Seeking refuge with the Lord of daybreak reminds him of his Lord's nurturing care and gentle governance. Relief may come gradually, as morning gradually emerges from night. So keep turning to Him, without making the soundness of your devotion depend on the disappearance of what troubles you at the moment you choose. In this way you reach the end of the Quran with a belief to live by: your Lord has no counterpart to whom you could turn instead, and your heart can never do without His mercy, guidance, and protection.